

Innovator Founder visa

1. Overview

You can apply for an Innovator Founder visa if:

- you want to set up and run an innovative business in the UK - it must be something that's different from anything else on the market
- your business or business idea has been endorsed by an approved body, also known as an [endorsing body \(/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator\)](/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator)
- you meet the other [eligibility requirements \(/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility\)](/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility)

This visa used to be called the Innovator visa.

Eligibility

You must be able to show that your business idea is:

- new - you cannot join a business that is already trading
- innovative - you must have an original business idea which is different from anything else on the market
- viable, with potential for growth
- scalable - you must give evidence of planning that includes creating jobs and growing into national and international markets

You'll need to get an [endorsing body \(/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator\)](/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator) to assess that your business idea meets the requirements.

Knowledge of English

You must be able to speak, read, write and understand English. You'll usually need to [prove your knowledge of English \(/innovator-founder-visa/knowledge-of-english\)](/innovator-founder-visa/knowledge-of-english) when you apply.

If you're not eligible for an Innovator Founder visa

You may be eligible for [another type of visa to work in the UK \(/check-uk-visa\)](/check-uk-visa).

How long you can stay

You can stay for 3 years if you either:

- come to the UK on an Innovator Founder visa
- switch to this visa from another visa while in the UK

You'll need to meet with your endorsing body after 12 months and 24 months to show you're making progress with your business. Your visa may be cut short if your endorsement is withdrawn by the endorsing body. If you want to stay longer, you must re-apply with a new endorsement before your current visa expires.

If you want to stay longer in the UK

You can [apply to extend your stay](https://www.gov.uk/innovator-visa/extend-your-visa) (<https://www.gov.uk/innovator-visa/extend-your-visa>) for another 3 years when your visa is due to expire. There's no limit on the number of times you can extend.

You may be able to apply for settlement once you've been in the UK for 3 years.

How to apply

You must apply online.

How you apply depends on whether you're:

- [outside the UK](/innovator-founder-visa/apply-from-outside-the-uk) (</innovator-founder-visa/apply-from-outside-the-uk>) and are coming to the UK
- inside the UK and [extending your current visa](/innovator-founder-visa/extend-your-visa) (</innovator-founder-visa/extend-your-visa>)
- inside the UK and [switching from a different visa](/innovator-founder-visa/switch-to-this-visa) (</innovator-founder-visa/switch-to-this-visa>)

[Your partner and children](/innovator-founder-visa/your-partner-and-children) (</innovator-founder-visa/your-partner-and-children>) can apply to join you or stay in the UK as your 'dependants' if they're eligible.

How long it takes

As part of your application, you'll need to prove your identity and provide your documents.

You may need to allow extra time if you need an appointment to do this. You'll find out if you need one when you start your application.

Getting a decision

Once you've applied online, proved your identity and provided your documents, you'll usually get a decision on your visa within:

- 3 weeks, if you're outside the UK
- 8 weeks, if you're inside the UK

You may be able to pay to [get a faster decision \(/faster-decision-visa-settlement\)](#).

Fees

How much you pay for an application depends on where you apply from.

It costs £1,357 per person if you apply outside the UK.

It costs £1,693 per person if you apply to extend or switch your visa in the UK.

Endorsement

You'll need to pay £1,000 to get an endorsement from an approved [endorsing body \(/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator-founder-and-scale-up-visas\)](#).

If your visa application is successful, you'll also have to pay £500 each time you meet with your endorsing body. You need to meet at least twice during your stay in the UK.

You pay these fees directly to your endorsing body.

Healthcare surcharge

You'll also have to [pay the healthcare surcharge \(/healthcare-immigration-application\)](#) as part of your application.

If you're applying to extend or switch in the UK

You'll also need to have your biometric information (fingerprints and a photo) taken - there's no fee for this.

What you can and cannot do

With an Innovator Founder visa you can:

- set up a business or several businesses
- work for your business - this includes being employed as a director, or self-employed as a member of a business partnership
- do work outside your business, as long as it's a job needing at least a level 3 qualification (</what-different-qualification-levels-mean/list-of-qualification-levels>)
- bring your partner and children with you as your 'dependants' (</innovator-founder-visa/your-partner-and-children>), if they're eligible
- travel abroad and return to the UK
- apply to settle permanently in the UK (also known as 'indefinite leave to remain') if you've lived in the UK for 3 years and meet the other eligibility requirements

You cannot:

- apply for most benefits ('public funds (</government/publications/public-funds-2>)')
- work as a professional sportsperson, for example a sports coach

If your application is successful, you'll get a full list of what you can and cannot do with an Innovator Founder visa.

2. Eligibility

Before you apply you need to have your business or business idea assessed by an endorsing body (</government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator>).

They will provide you with an endorsement letter if your business is eligible.

You must also:

- meet the English language requirement (</innovator-founder-visa/knowledge-of-english>)
- be at least 18 years old
- be able to prove that you have enough personal savings to support yourself while you're in the UK

Read the [specific requirements for the Innovator Founder visa \(/guidance/immigration-rules/immigration-rules-appendix-innovator-founder\)](/guidance/immigration-rules/immigration-rules-appendix-innovator-founder) before you apply.

If you want to set up a new business

You'll need to prove to your endorsing body that you have enough funding and where it's from.

You do not need any investment funds if either:

- your business is already established and has been endorsed for an earlier visa
- you've changed your business and already agreed it with your endorsing body

Supporting yourself

You need to have had at least £1,270 in your bank account for 28 consecutive days before you either:

- apply for an Innovator Founder visa
- apply to [extend your Innovator Founder visa \(/innovator-founder-visa/extend-your-visa\)](/innovator-founder-visa/extend-your-visa) or [switch to an Innovator Founder visa \(/innovator-founder-visa/switch-to-this-visa\)](/innovator-founder-visa/switch-to-this-visa) if you've been in the UK for less than a year

You cannot use either of the following to support yourself:

- money from your investment funds
- money earned while working in the UK illegally

Read the [guidance on financial evidence \(/guidance/financial-evidence-for-sponsored-or-endorsed-work-routes\)](/guidance/financial-evidence-for-sponsored-or-endorsed-work-routes) for more information about the money you need and how to prove it.

3. Knowledge of English

You'll usually need to prove your knowledge of the English language when you apply. You can prove it in one of the following ways, by:

- having a UK school qualification
- having a degree from a UK institution

- having a degree from an institution that was outside the UK and taught in English
- passing an English test from an approved provider

If you have already proved your knowledge of English in a previous successful visa application, you may not have to prove it again.

If you have a UK school qualification

You can prove your knowledge of English if you have a qualification from a UK school that you began when you were under 18. You must have one of the following qualifications:

- a GCSE
- an A Level
- Scottish National Qualification level 4 or 5
- Scottish Higher or Advanced Higher in English

If you have a degree from a UK institution

You can prove your knowledge of English if you have a degree-level qualification that was both:

- taught in English
- awarded by a UK institution, even if you studied outside the UK

If you have a degree from an institution outside the UK

If your degree was taught in English and was not awarded by a UK institution, you'll need to [apply for an assessment from Ecctis](https://qls.ecctis.com/) (<https://qls.ecctis.com/>).

Ecctis will give you a code to confirm that your qualification is equivalent to a UK bachelors degree or higher and was taught in English.

Passing an English test

If you do not have any qualifications that prove your knowledge of English, you will need to [pass a Secure English Language Test \(SELT\)](/guidance/prove-your-english-language-abilities-with-a-secure-english-language-test-selt) (</guidance/prove-your-english-language-abilities-with-a-secure-english-language-test-selt>) with an approved provider.

You must prove you can read, write speak and understand English to at least B2 level on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR) scale (<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/table-1-cefr-3.3-common-reference-levels-global-scale>).

Who does not need to prove their knowledge of English

You will not need to prove your knowledge of English if you're a national of one of the following countries or territories:

- Antigua and Barbuda
- Australia
- the Bahamas
- Barbados
- Belize
- the British overseas territories
- Canada
- Dominica
- Grenada
- Guyana
- Jamaica
- Malta
- New Zealand
- St Kitts and Nevis
- St Lucia
- St Vincent and the Grenadines
- Trinidad and Tobago
- USA

4. Documents you'll need to apply

When you apply you need to provide an 'endorsement letter' to show that an endorsing body (</government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator>) has assessed your business or business idea.

You also need to provide:

- a valid passport or other document that shows your identity and nationality
- bank statements showing you've had at least £1,270 in savings in your bank account for 28 consecutive days before you apply
- proof that you meet the [English language requirement \(/innovator-founder-visa/knowledge-of-english\)](/innovator-founder-visa/knowledge-of-english)
- your [tuberculosis test results \(/tb-test-visa\)](/tb-test-visa) if you're from a country where you have to take the test

If your documents are not in English or Welsh you'll also need to provide a [certified translation \(/certifying-a-document\)](/certifying-a-document).

You may need to provide additional documents depending on your circumstances.

5. Apply from outside the UK

You must apply online for an Innovator Founder visa.

Check which [documents you'll need to apply \(/innovator-founder-visa/documents-youll-need-to-apply\)](/innovator-founder-visa/documents-youll-need-to-apply).

Proving your identity and supplying supporting documents

As part of your application, you'll need to prove your identity. How you do this depends on where you're from and what type of passport you have.

You'll either:

- use the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' app to scan your identity document - you'll also create or sign into your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account
- have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a [visa application centre \(/find-a-visa-application-centre\)](/find-a-visa-application-centre)

You'll be told what you need to do when you apply.

If you need an appointment:

- you'll need to take your passport with you to the visa application centre (you'll be able to collect it on the day)

- you may have to travel to get to your nearest centre (this could be in another country)

Apply for an Innovator Founder visa

Once you've started your application, you can save your form and complete it later.

[Start now](#)

Continue your application

You can sign back into your application if you've saved it.

[Find out how to sign in to your account \(/sign-in-visa\)](/sign-in-visa).

How long it takes to get a decision

Once you've applied online, proved your identity and provided your documents, you'll usually get a decision within 3 weeks.

You'll be contacted if your application will take longer, for example:

- if you're applying with a family member who needs an appointment but you do not
- if your supporting documents need to be verified
- if you need to attend an interview
- because of your personal circumstances, for example if you have a criminal conviction

You may be able to pay to [get a faster decision \(/faster-decision-visa-settlement\)](/faster-decision-visa-settlement).

After you apply

If you need to change something in your application after you've sent it [contact UK Visas and Immigration \(UKVI\) \(/contact-ukvi-inside-outside-uk\)](/contact-ukvi-inside-outside-uk).

You can ask to [cancel your application \(/cancel-visa\)](/cancel-visa). You'll only get your fee refunded if UKVI has not started processing your application.

You'll get an email containing the [decision on your application \(/apply-to-come-to-the-uk/getting-a-decision-on-your-application\)](/apply-to-come-to-the-uk/getting-a-decision-on-your-application). This will explain what you need to do next.

6. Your partner and children

Your partner and children can also apply to join you or stay in the UK as your 'dependants' if they're eligible.

If your partner or child's application is successful, their visa will usually end on the same date as yours. If a child's parents have visas with different expiry dates, the child's visa will end on the earlier date.

A dependant partner or child is any of the following:

- your husband, wife, civil partner or unmarried partner
- your child under 18 - including if they were born in the UK during your stay
- your child over 18 if they currently have permission ('leave to enter' or 'leave to remain') to be in the UK as your dependant

You'll need to provide evidence of your relationship to your dependant when you apply.

Your partner

You must be able to prove one of the following:

- you're in a civil partnership or marriage that's recognised in the UK
- you've been living together in a relationship for at least 2 years when you apply
- you've been in a relationship for at least 2 years when you apply but you cannot live together, for example because you're working or studying in different places, or it's not accepted in your culture

If you're not living together, you'll need to prove that you have an ongoing commitment to each other, for example by providing evidence that you:

- communicate regularly with each other
- support each other financially
- care for any children you have together
- spend time together as a couple, for example on holiday or at events

Your child

They must:

- live with you, unless they're living away from home in full-time education - for example, at boarding school or university
- not be married or in a civil partnership

You'll need to provide evidence of their address, such as:

- a bank statement
- credit card bills
- driving licence
- NHS registration document
- an official letter from their university or college

Money they need to support themselves

Your partner and children must each have a certain amount of money available to support themselves while they're in the UK.

In addition to the £1,270 you must have to support yourself, you - or your partner or child - will need:

- £285 for your partner
- £315 for one child
- £200 for each additional child

Example

You must have £1,870 if you want to bring your partner and 1 child with you to the UK: £1,270 to support yourself + £285 for your partner + £315 for your child.

You'll need to have had the money in your bank account or your dependant's bank account for at least 28 days before you or they apply.

You'll usually need to show proof of this when you apply (/innovator-founder-visa/documents-youll-need-to-apply), unless you or they are applying from inside the UK and you've been here for 1 year or more.

Apply from outside the UK

Your partner and children must either:

- [apply online as a partner \(https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_partner_out_uk\)](https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_partner_out_uk)
- [apply online as a child \(https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_child_out_uk\)](https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_child_out_uk)

Each family member will need to complete a separate application and pay the [visa fee \(/innovator-founder-visa\)](#). They must apply before they travel to the UK.

They'll also need your application number - you'll get this when you apply. This number is called a Global Web Form (GWF) or a Unique Application Number (UAN). You'll find it on emails and letters from the Home Office about your application.

They'll need to have their fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a [visa application centre \(/find-a-visa-application-centre\)](#) as part of their application.

How long it takes to get a decision

Once they've applied online, proved their identity and provided their documents, they'll usually get a decision within 3 weeks.

They may be able to pay to [get a faster decision \(/faster-decision-visa-settlement\)](#).

Apply from inside the UK (extend or switch)

If you extend or switch your visa, your partner or child's current visa will still be valid until its original end date. Your partner or child need to apply to extend or switch their visa, either:

- at the same time as you
- at any time before their current visa expires

This includes children who have turned 18 during your stay.

Your partner or children will not be able to apply to switch to an Innovator Founder visa if they are currently in the UK in one of the following circumstances:

- on a visit visa
- on a short-term student visa
- on a Parent of a Child Student visa
- on a seasonal worker visa
- on a domestic worker in a private household visa
- on immigration bail ([/bail-immigration-detainees](#))
- they were given permission to stay outside the immigration rules ([/government/publications/chapter-1-section-14-leave-outside-the-immigration-rules/leave-outside-the-immigration-rules-accessible-version](#)), for example on compassionate grounds

If your partner or child is currently in the UK on a Student visa, they can only switch if they have either:

- completed the course they were sponsored to study
- studied for a PhD for at least 24 months

How to apply

The application form will tell you if you can include your partner and children in your application or whether they need to apply separately.

If your partner or child apply separately, they'll need to either:

- extend or switch to an Innovator Founder visa as your partner (https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_partner_in_uk)
- extend or switch to an Innovator Founder visa as your child (https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/pbs_dependant_child_in_uk)

They'll need your application number - you'll get this when you apply. This number is called a Global Web Form (GWF) or a Unique Application Number (UAN). You'll find it on emails and letters from the Home Office about your application.

They'll need to have their fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) ([/ukvcas](#)) service point as part of their application.

They'll also need to submit their supporting documents. They can:

- upload them into the online service
- have them scanned at their UKVCAS appointment

They must not travel outside of the UK, Ireland, the Channel Islands or the Isle of Man until they get a decision. Their application will be withdrawn if they do.

Getting a faster decision

They may be able to pay to get a faster decision (/faster-decision-visa-settlement).

If their application is successful

They'll get an eVisa (an online record of their immigration status).

Their decision email or letter will tell them how to get access to their eVisa (/get-access-evisa). They'll need to create a UKVI account.

Children born in the UK

If you have a child while you're in the UK, they do not automatically become a British citizen (/british-citizenship).

You can apply online for their dependant visa (https://apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/live-in-crown-dependency/pbs_dependant_child_in_uk?uid=baf68c95-0d6e-4a35-a156-fcf3fc346264). You must do this if you want to travel in and out of the UK with your child.

You'll need to provide a full UK birth certificate for each child, showing the names of both parents.

You must apply for their dependant visa before they turn 18 if they want to stay in the UK.

What your partner or child can and cannot do

Your partner or child can:

- work, except as a sportsperson or coach
- study
- travel abroad and return to the UK

- apply to settle permanently in the UK (also known as ‘indefinite leave to remain’) if they’ve lived in the UK for 5 years and meet the other eligibility requirements

They cannot apply for most benefits (public funds), or the State Pension.

If their application is successful, they’ll get a full list of what they can and cannot do.

7. Extend your visa

You can usually apply to extend an Innovator Founder visa if both of the following apply:

- you meet the [eligibility requirements \(/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility\)](/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility)
- you’re still running a business in the UK or want to set up a new one

Your partner or child’s visa will not automatically extend if you extend yours. If they do not extend their visa, it will be valid until its original end date.

They can either apply at the same time as you, or at any time before their current visa expires.

You should apply before your current visa expires.

You need to have your business or business idea assessed by [an endorsing body \(/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator\)](/government/publications/endorsing-bodies-innovator) when you extend your visa.

Fees

[Check how much money you’ll need \(/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility\)](/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility) to extend your visa and support yourself while you’re in the UK.

You’ll also need to have your biometric information (fingerprints and a photo) taken - there’s no fee for this.

Proving your identity and supplying supporting documents

As part of your application you’ll need to prove your identity. How you do this depends on where you’re from and the type of passport you have.

You’ll either:

- use the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' app to scan your identity document - you'll also create or sign in to your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account
- have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) (/ukvcas) service point

You'll be told what you need to do when you apply.

Apply in the UK

You must apply online.

Once you've started your application, you can save your form and complete it later.

Start now

You must not travel outside of the UK, Ireland, the Channel Islands or the Isle of Man until you get a decision. Your application will be withdrawn if you do.

Apply outside the UK

You can apply online (/apply-to-visit-or-stay-in-the-uk.homeoffice.gov.uk/sort/start/start_up_and_innovator_out_uk) to extend an Innovator Founder visa you've had in the last year.

You may also be able to apply at a visa application centre. You can apply from any country as long as you've been given permission to live there for at least 6 months. Check if there's a visa application centre (/find-a-visa-application-centre) that you can travel to that accepts Innovator Founder visa applications.

Continue your application

You can sign back into your application if you've saved it.

Find out how to sign in to your account (/sign-in-visa).

How long it takes to get a decision

You'll usually get a decision within 8 weeks of your application date.

You'll be contacted if your application will take longer, for example:

- if you're applying with a family member who needs an appointment but you do not
- if your supporting documents need to be verified
- if you need to attend an interview
- because of your personal circumstances, for example if you have a criminal conviction

You may be able to pay to [get a faster decision \(/faster-decision-visa-settlement\)](/faster-decision-visa-settlement).

After you apply

If you need to change something in your application after you've sent it [contact UK Visas and Immigration \(UKVI\) \(/contact-ukvi-inside-outside-uk\)](/contact-ukvi-inside-outside-uk).

You can ask to [cancel your application \(/cancel-visa\)](/cancel-visa). You'll only get your fee refunded if UKVI has not started processing your application.

You'll get an email or a letter containing the [decision on your application \(/apply-to-come-to-the-uk/getting-a-decision-on-your-application\)](/apply-to-come-to-the-uk/getting-a-decision-on-your-application). This will explain what you need to do next.

Once you've applied you can stay in the UK until you've been given a decision, as long as you applied before your last visa expired.

8. Switch to this visa

You might be able to apply to change ('switch') to an Innovator Founder visa if you're already in the UK on a different type of visa.

Your partner or child's visa will not automatically switch to this visa if you switch yours. If they do not switch their visa, it will be valid until its original end date. They can either apply at the same time as you, or at any time before their current visa expires.

You should apply before your current visa expires.

Eligibility

You can apply to switch to this visa if you meet the [eligibility requirements \(/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility\)](/innovator-founder-visa/eligibility).

If you're currently in the UK on a Student visa, one of the following must also apply:

- you've completed the course you were sponsored to study
- you're studying for a PhD full time, and have been for at least 24 months

Who cannot apply to switch to this visa

You cannot switch to this visa if you have one of the following:

- a visit visa
- a short-term student visa
- a Parent of a Child Student visa
- a seasonal worker visa
- a domestic worker in a private household visa
- [immigration bail \(/bail-immigration-detainees\)](/bail-immigration-detainees)
- [permission to stay outside the immigration rules \(/government/publications/chapter-1-section-14-leave-outside-the-immigration-rules/leave-outside-the-immigration-rules-accessible-version\)](/government/publications/chapter-1-section-14-leave-outside-the-immigration-rules/leave-outside-the-immigration-rules-accessible-version), for example on compassionate grounds

How long you can stay

You can stay for 3 years after switching to an Innovator Founder visa.

There's no limit on the number of times you can extend your visa.

How much it costs

[Check the visa application fees \(/innovator-founder-visa\)](/innovator-founder-visa).

If you've been in the UK for less than 1 year, you'll also need to prove you have enough money to support yourself (</innovator-founder-visa/eligibility>).

Proving your identity and supplying supporting documents

As part of your application you'll need to prove your identity. How you do this depends on where you're from and the type of passport you have.

You'll either:

- use the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' app to scan your identity document - you'll also create or sign in to your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account
- have your fingerprints and photo (biometric information) taken at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) (</ukvcas>) service point

You'll be told what you need to do when you apply.

Apply to switch to an Innovator Founder visa

You must apply online.

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You can ask to [cancel your application \(/cancel-visa\)](#). You'll only get your fee refunded if UKVI has not started processing your application.

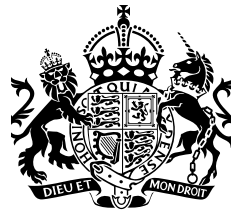
You'll get an email or a letter containing the [decision on your application \(/apply-to-come-to-the-uk/getting-a-decision-on-your-application\)](#). This will explain what you need to do next.

Once you've applied you can stay in the UK until you've been given a decision, as long as you applied before your last visa expired.





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